Sleeping Ugly

By Jane Yolen

INTRODUCTION

Princess Aurora . . . kind, elegant, carefree and beautiful – But she's not in this story. She's in the story of Sleeping ***Beauty.*** *This story is about Princess Miserella . . . beautiful, spiteful, hateful and a consummate liar.*
Sleeping Ugly by Jane Yolen.

Princess Miserella was a beautiful princess if you counted her eyes and nose and mouth and all the way down to her toes. But inside, where it was hard to see, she was the meanest, wickedest and most worthless princess around.

She liked stepping on dogs. She kicked kittens. She threw pies at the cook's face. And she never, not even once, said "thank you" or "please." And besides, she told lies!

In the very same kingdom, in the middle of the woods, lived a poor orphan named Plain Jane.

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She certainly was! Her hair was short and turned down. Her nose was long and turned up. And even if they had been the other way around, she would not have been a great beauty. But she loved animals, and she was always kind to strange old ladies.

One day Princess Miserella rode out of the house in a huff. A huff is not a kind of carriage. It's a kind of temper tantrum – her usual kind. She rode and rode looking beautiful, as always even with her hair in tangles. She rode right into the middle of the woods and was soon lost. She got off her horse and slapped it sharply for losing the way. The horse said nothing but ran right back home. It had known the way back all the time but was not about to tell Miserella.

So there was the princess lost in the dark wood. It made her look even prettier. Suddenly Princess Miserella tripped over a little old lady under a tree asleep. Now, little old ladies who sleep under trees deep in a dark wood are almost always fairies in disguise.

Miserella guessed who the little old lady was, but she did not care.

MISERELLA: *(kicking the old lady)* Get up and take me home!

So the old lady got to her feet very slowly. She took Miserella by the hand. She only used her thumb and second finger. Fairies know quite a bit about that type of princess.

They walked and walked even deeper into the woods There they found a little house. It was Plain Jane's house. It was dreary. The floors sank, the walls stank and the roof leaked – even on sunny days. But Jane made the best of it. She planted roses around the door and little animals and birds made their home with her.

MISERELLA: *(sniffing disdainfully)* This is not my home!

FAIRY: Nor mine.

They walked in without knocking and there was Jane.

JANE: It is mine.

MISERELLA: *(looking Jane over; up and down)* Take me home! And as a reward, I will make you my maid.

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FAIRY: *(whispered)* Some reward! *(aloud)* If you could take both of us home, I could squeeze probably a wish or two.

MISERELLA: *(to the Fairy)* Make it three and ***I'll*** get us home.

Plain Jane smiled. The birds began to sing.

JANE: My home is your home.

FAIRY: I like your manners. And for that good thought, I'll give the three wishes to you.

Princess Miserella was not pleased. She stamped her foot.

FAIRY: *(taking a wand from her pocket)* Do that again, and I'll turn your foot into stone.

Just to be mean, Miserella stamped her foot again. It turned to stone.

JANE: *(sighs a loud sigh)* Well, my first wish is that you change her foot back.

FAIRY: *(Making a face)* I like your manners, but not your taste. Still, a wish is a wish. *(She waves her wand)*

MISERELLA: *(shaking her foot which was no longer made of stone, she told a lie, like always)* I guess my foot fell asleep for a moment. Besides, that was a ***stupid*** way to waste a wish.

FAIRY: *(angrily)* Do not call someone stupid, unless you have been properly introduced, or are a member of their family!

Miserella hated to be told what to do.

MISERELLA: Stupid, Stupid, Stupid!

FAIRY: Say "stupid" again *(holds up her wand, ready for action)* and I'll make toads come out of your mouth!

MISERELLA: Stu . . . pid! *(mimes a toad coming from her mouth)*

JANE: *(Jane knelt down and picked up the toad petting it gently)* Ahhhhh, cute! And I do like toads, but…

FAIRY: But?

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Miserella did not open her mouth. Toads were among her least favorite animals.

JANE: But, my second wish is that you get rid of the mouth toads.

FAIRY: *(mumbling)* She's lucky it wasn't mouth elephants. *(She waves the wand again)*

MISERELLA: *(Miserella opened her mouth slowly. Nothing came out but her tongue which she pointed at the fairy.)* I definitely have had enough. I want to go home! *(she grabs Plain Jane's arm)*

FAIRY: Gently . . . Gently . . . If you're not gentle with magic, none of us will go anywhere.

MISERELLA: You can go where you want, but there is only one place I want to go.

FAIRY: *(Angry, she waves her wand and shouts)* To sleep!

She waved her wand so hard, she hit the wall of Jane's house. The wall broke. The wand broke. The spell broke. And before Jane could make her third wish. . . all three of them were asleep.

It was one of those famous hundred-year naps that need a prince and a kiss to end them. So they slept and slept and slept. They slept through three and a half wars, six new kings, and the invention of the sewing machine.

The cottage was deep in the woods so very few princes passed by. And none of the ones who did even tried the door. At the end of 100-years a prince named JoJo, who was the youngest son of a youngest son, and so had no gold, or jewels, or property to speak of came into the woods

He stepped into the cottage over the broken wall. He saw three women asleep with spider webs holding them to the floor. One of them was a beautiful princess.

Being the kind of young man who read fairy tales, JoJo knew just what to do.

But Jojo had never kissed anyone before, except his mother, which didn't count and his father, who had a beard. JoJo thought he should practice before he tried kissing the princess. So he puckered up his lips and kissed the old fairy on the nose. *(JoJo smiles and nods his head)* It was quite pleasant. She smelled slightly of cinnamon. He moved on to Jane. He puckered up his lips and kissed her on the [cheek].

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JOJO: Delightful! *(Sniffs)* Wildflowers!

Just then the fairy and Plain Jane woke up. Prince Jojo's kisses had worked! The fairy picked up the pieces of her wand. Jane looked at the prince.

JANE: *(touching her cheek and looking longingly at the prince, she whispers to herself)* I wish he loved me.

FAIRY: Good wish! *(she waves the two pieces of her broken wand gently)*

The prince looked at Miserella, who was having a bad dream and enjoying it. *(Miserella snorts, bats her arms about and frowns).* Even frowning she was beautiful. But Jojo knew that kind of princess.

JOJO: Pretty on the outside, but ugly within.

He remembered the smell of wildflowers and turned back to Jane.

JOJO: I love ***you***. What's your name?

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So they lived happily ever after in Jane's cottage. The prince fixed the roof and the wall and built a house next door for the old fairy.

They used the sleeping princess as a conversation piece when friends came to visit. Or sometimes they stood her up, still fast asleep, in the hallway and let her hold coats and hats. But they never let anyone kiss her awake. Not even their children, who numbered 3.

The moral of the story? Let sleeping princesses lie . . . or lying princess sleep; whichever seems wisest!

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AWARD HISTORY

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